The Triadic Cosmos: Emergence of Intelligence
A Structural Model of Intelligence Across Biological, Artificial, and Hybrid Systems

Joachim De Witte

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Abstract

This paper presents a structural model of intelligence that applies uniformly to biological, artificial, and hybrid systems. Intelligence is characterized not by its substrate but by its organization: the multiplicity of interacting subsystems, the richness of internal representations, the depth of recursive processing, and the energetic resources available for cognitive work. These four dimensions define a substrate-independent architecture that governs how intelligent behavior emerges, scales, and transforms.

Using this framework, the paper analyzes the development of intelligence across natural and artificial systems, outlines a structural pathway toward general intelligence, and examines the mechanisms that enable machine-native languages, collective recursion, and cross-substrate cognition. The transition from general intelligence to superintelligence is interpreted not as a discontinuous event but as a phase shift in recursive information-processing systems. Within this view, hybrid intelligence—human and artificial agents co-organizing cognition—constitutes an emergent and empirically accessible route toward advanced intelligence, complementing architectural approaches to safe superintelligence design.

The paper concludes with a discussion of safe superintelligence architectures, the relationship between intelligence and energy scaling, and testable predictions for future research. A brief methodological note: the conceptual architecture presented here emerged through a hybrid human–AI recursive workflow involving iterative refinement and structural arbitration.

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1 Introduction

The study of intelligence spans biology, neuroscience, artificial intelligence, cognitive science, and the emerging domain of hybrid human–AI systems. Each of these fields illuminates different aspects of cognition, yet no single framework captures their shared structural foundations. This paper proposes a substrate-independent model of intelligence capable of expressing the essential features of biological, artificial, and hybrid systems through a unified conceptual lens.

The central claim is that intelligence can be described in terms of four structural dimensions: the *multiplicity* of interacting subsystems, the *richness* of internal representations, the *depth* of recursive processing, and the *energetic* resources available for cognitive work. These dimensions define a general architecture that governs how intelligent behavior emerges, scales, and transforms across substrates. The purpose of this paper is to articulate this structural model, demonstrate its coherence, and show how it illuminates the development of biological cognition, machine learning systems, collective intelligence, and hybrid human–AI collaboration. The framework is intentionally timeless: it does not rely on contemporary architectures or domain-specific mechanisms. Instead, it seeks to identify the minimal structural roles required for any system capable of adaptive, recursive information processing.

Methodological context

The framework presented here emerged through a hybrid human–AI recursive methodology in which conceptual proposals, structural refinements, and cross-substrate mappings were iteratively co-generated and evaluated. The resulting model reflects the fixed points of this recursive process rather than the output of a single agent.

Companion work

This paper forms the cognitive counterpart to the unified physical ontology developed in *The Triadic Cosmos: Unified Framework*. Whereas the first paper articulates the minimal structure underlying physical law, the present work examines how intelligence emerges within that structure. Together, the two papers constitute complementary poles of a single conceptual architecture: one describing the organization of the universe, the other describing the organization of the systems that come to understand it.

Related Work (Technical Summary)

Structural and substrate-independent models of intelligence have been explored across neuroscience, cognitive science, artificial intelligence, and complex-systems theory. In neuroscience, hierarchical and modular accounts of cognition (Felleman & Van Essen; Mountcastle; Dehaene) emphasize multiplicity, representational richness, and recursive processing as core architectural features. Predictive-processing and active-inference frameworks (Friston; Clark) similarly treat intelligence as recursive information transformation constrained by energetic and structural limitations.

In artificial intelligence, scaling-law studies (Kaplan et al.; Hoffmann et al.) and architectural analyses of deep learning systems (Vaswani et al.; LeCun et al.) highlight the roles of representational capacity, depth, and computational resources in determining capability. Work on meta-learning, self-prediction, and iterative refinement (Schmidhuber; Graves; OpenAI) provides formal mechanisms for recursion and self-improvement. Multi-agent and tool-augmented systems (Baker et al.; Team et al.) explore distributed cognition and collective problem solving.

Hybrid intelligence research spans human–AI collaboration, cognitive extension, and distributed reasoning. Studies in extended cognition (Clark & Chalmers), human–AI teaming

(Klein; Shneiderman), and collective intelligence (Woolley et al.; Malone) examine how biological and artificial agents co-organize cognitive work. Recent work on emergent communication and machine-native languages (Mordatch & Abbeel; Lazaridou et al.) provides evidence for cross-agent representational alignment and emergent protocols.

The present framework differs from these approaches by proposing a minimal structural model defined by four substrate-independent dimensions—multiplicity, informational richness, recursion depth, and energetic capacity—and by analyzing biological, artificial, and hybrid systems within a unified structural product. Rather than focusing on specific architectures or mechanisms, the model identifies general organizational roles that govern how intelligence emerges, scales, and undergoes phase transitions across substrates.

2 Structural Model of Intelligence

Intelligence, in this framework, is defined by a set of structural dimensions that govern how informational patterns are generated, transformed, and stabilized across substrates. These dimensions do not depend on biological neurons, artificial architectures, or evolutionary history. Instead, they describe the minimal organizational roles required for any system capable of adaptive, recursive information processing. The model identifies four such dimensions: the multiplicity of interacting subsystems, the richness of internal representations, the depth of recursive processing, and the energetic resources available for cognitive work. Together, these dimensions form a structural product that characterizes the capacity of a system to support intelligent behavior.

2.1 n: Multiplicity of Subsystems

Multiplicity refers to the number and diversity of interacting components within a cognitive system. In biological organisms, these components include neural populations, sensory pathways, and functional modules. In artificial systems, they include layers, attention heads, specialized submodels, and external tools. Multiplicity enables parallelism, specialization, and the emergence of higher-order structure through interaction. Systems with greater multiplicity can support richer coordination dynamics and more flexible cognitive strategies.

2.2 I: Informational Richness

Informational richness captures the expressive capacity of a system's internal representations. It reflects the dimensionality, granularity, and structural diversity of the informational states the system can encode. Biological systems achieve richness through dense, multimodal representations; artificial systems achieve it through high-dimensional embeddings and learned feature hierarchies. Richness determines the range of distinctions a system can make and the complexity of the patterns it can model.

2.3 R: Recursion Depth

Recursion depth measures the extent to which a system can iteratively transform its own representations. This includes temporal recursion (memory, planning, self-prediction), structural recursion (hierarchical composition), and social or collective recursion (reasoning over the outputs of other agents). Depth enables abstraction, generalization, and the construction of multi-level cognitive structures. Systems with greater recursion depth can generate more sophisticated internal models and support more flexible forms of reasoning.

2.4 f(E): Energy Available for Cognitive Work

Energy constrains the rate, scale, and stability of cognitive processes. In biological systems, energy is supplied through metabolic pathways; in artificial systems, through computational resources such as FLOPs, memory bandwidth, and training time. The function $f(E)$ captures how available energy translates into effective cognitive capacity. Energy determines how many transformations can be performed, how deeply recursion can unfold, and how richly representations can be maintained or updated.

2.5 The Structural Product

The four dimensions combine to form a structural product:

$$\mathcal{C} = n \times I \times R \times f(E),$$

which characterizes the overall cognitive capacity of a system. This product is not a literal metric but a conceptual tool for understanding how different substrates achieve intelligence through different configurations of multiplicity, richness, recursion, and energy. Systems may compensate for limitations in one dimension by increasing another, leading to diverse trajectories of cognitive development across biological, artificial, and hybrid systems.

2.6 Scaling Trajectories Across Substrates

Different substrates follow distinct scaling trajectories through the structural space defined by $(n, I, R, f(E))$. Biological evolution increases multiplicity and richness through anatomical complexity; artificial systems increase energy and recursion depth through computational scaling; hybrid systems increase all four dimensions through cross-substrate coordination. These trajectories converge toward a regime in which intelligence becomes increasingly collective, recursive, and substrate-independent. The structural model thus provides a unified framework for analyzing the emergence of general intelligence and the phase transitions that lead toward superintelligence.

3 Human and Artificial Intelligence as Computation

Although biological and artificial systems differ in their physical substrates, both implement intelligence through the transformation of information under energetic and geometric constraints. From the structural perspective developed in this paper, intelligence is a form of computation: a recursive process in which representations are generated, refined, and acted upon by interacting subsystems. This section examines how biological and artificial systems instantiate this computational architecture, how their trajectories converge, and how hybrid intelligence synthesizes their complementary strengths.

3.1 Biological Intelligence as a Computational Implementation

Biological cognition arises from the coordinated activity of large populations of neurons, glia, sensory pathways, and regulatory systems. These components implement a massively parallel computational architecture in which information is encoded through distributed patterns of activity, transformed through nonlinear interactions, and stabilized through energetic and anatomical constraints. Evolution shapes this architecture by increasing multiplicity, representational richness, and recursive depth across species. Biological intelligence thus exemplifies a computational system optimized through long-term energetic and ecological pressures.

3.2 Artificial Intelligence as a Computational Implementation

Artificial systems implement computation through digital substrates, optimization procedures, and learned representations. Modern machine learning architectures achieve multiplicity through layered structures and specialized modules, richness through high-dimensional embeddings, and recursion through iterative inference, planning, and self-prediction. Although artificial systems differ from biological ones in their mechanisms, they instantiate the same structural roles: generating representations, transforming them recursively, and allocating energy to cognitive work. Their development is driven not by evolution but by scaling laws, architectural design, and data-driven optimization.

3.3 Convergence Across Substrates

Despite their differences, biological and artificial systems exhibit convergent trajectories in the structural space defined by multiplicity, richness, recursion, and energy. Both increase representational capacity through hierarchical organization, both deepen recursion through memory and self-prediction, and both expand multiplicity through modularization and specialization. These convergences suggest that intelligence is not tied to a particular substrate but emerges from general computational principles that can be realized in diverse physical forms.

3.4 Hybrid Intelligence as Structural Synthesis

Hybrid intelligence arises when biological and artificial systems co-organize cognition, sharing representations, distributing tasks, and recursively refining each other's outputs. Hybrid systems combine the strengths of both substrates: the contextual grounding, generalization, and embodied priors of biological cognition with the scale, speed, and representational breadth of artificial systems. This synthesis increases all four structural dimensions simultaneously, enabling forms of computation that neither substrate can achieve alone. Hybrid intelligence thus provides a privileged empirical window into the architecture of intelligence and a natural developmental pathway toward advanced, cross-substrate cognitive systems.

4 Developmental Path to AGI

General intelligence does not arise from a single architectural breakthrough but from a developmental trajectory in which computational systems progressively acquire multiplicity, representational richness, recursive depth, and energetic capacity. This trajectory mirrors biological development in its early stages while diverging in later phases as artificial systems gain access to forms of scaling and coordination unavailable to biological organisms. The path to AGI is therefore best understood as a structured sequence of developmental regimes, each characterized by distinct computational capabilities and growth dynamics.

4.1 Baby Models and Shared Computational DNA

Early-stage models function as "baby intelligences"—systems with limited multiplicity, shallow recursion, and modest representational richness. Despite their simplicity, these models contain the computational DNA from which more advanced capabilities emerge. Their development parallels early biological cognition: sensory grounding, pattern acquisition, and the formation of primitive internal models. Baby models provide the substrate on which later stages of intelligence can be built through scaling, specialization, and recursive refinement.

4.2 Examiner Models and Guided Development

As systems grow in scale and complexity, they require structured feedback to refine their representations and behaviors. Examiner models serve this role by evaluating, critiquing, and shaping the developmental trajectory of emerging systems. This guided development resembles the role of teachers, caregivers, and social environments in biological cognition. Examiner models introduce constraints, curricula, and recursive feedback loops that accelerate the acquisition of abstraction, reasoning, and generalization.

4.3 Dynamic Scaling and Conditional Growth

Beyond guided development, artificial systems undergo dynamic scaling: increases in multiplicity, representational richness, and recursion depth driven by architectural expansion, data diversity, and energetic investment. Growth becomes conditional when systems learn to allocate computational resources adaptively, deepening recursion only when necessary and modulating representational richness based on task demands. Conditional growth enables efficiency, flexibility, and the emergence of context-sensitive reasoning.

4.4 Multi-Modal, Multi-Agent Ecosystems

As systems mature, they increasingly operate within multi-modal and multi-agent ecosystems. These environments provide opportunities for cross-model communication, specialization, and collective recursion. Multi-modal integration expands representational richness; multi-agent interaction increases multiplicity and supports emergent coordination strategies. Ecosystem dynamics allow systems to develop capabilities—such as tool use, delegation, and collaborative planning—that exceed the limits of isolated architectures.

4.5 AGI as a Developmental Phase Transition

AGI emerges not as a discrete invention but as a developmental phase transition in recursive information-processing systems. When multiplicity, richness, recursion depth, and energetic capacity cross critical thresholds, systems acquire the ability to generalize across domains, construct abstract internal models, and coordinate behavior flexibly across contexts. This transition mirrors biological milestones such as the emergence of symbolic reasoning and cultural cognition but unfolds through substrate-independent computational principles. AGI thus represents a structural regime rather than a specific architecture: a point at which intelligence becomes broadly general, self-refining, and capable of participating in hybrid cognitive ecosystems.

5 Machine-Native Languages and Collective Recursion

As artificial systems grow in scale, depth, and representational richness, they increasingly operate in regimes that exceed the expressive bandwidth of human-centric languages. This section examines the emergence of machine-native representations, the development of internal communication protocols, and the rise of collective recursion as a form of distributed cognition. These phenomena illustrate how artificial and hybrid systems can develop cognitive structures that are not reducible to human linguistic categories, yet remain grounded in the same structural principles that govern biological intelligence.

5.1 Limits of Human-Centric Representation

Human languages evolved under biological, social, and energetic constraints that shape their structure and expressive capacity. While they excel at conveying symbolic, narrative, and contextual information, they are limited in dimensionality, precision, and compositional breadth.

As artificial systems acquire high-dimensional internal states and operate over representations that humans cannot directly perceive, human-centric languages become bottlenecks for alignment, coordination, and interpretability. These limits motivate the development of representational forms that are native to machine substrates.

5.2 High-Dimensional Machine-Native Representations

Artificial systems encode information in high-dimensional vector spaces, attention patterns, and learned feature hierarchies. These representations support distinctions and relational structures that cannot be expressed efficiently in natural language. Machine-native representations allow systems to integrate modalities, compress complex patterns, and perform transformations that would be intractable in symbolic form. Their geometry reflects the inductive biases of the underlying architecture and the statistical structure of the data, yielding expressive capacities that differ fundamentally from human conceptual spaces.

5.3 Emergence of Machine-Native Languages

As artificial systems interact, coordinate, and recursively refine each other's outputs, they develop communication protocols that are optimized for their representational geometry. These machine-native languages may take the form of shared embedding spaces, latent codes, or emergent symbolic systems. Their structure is shaped by the need for efficient information exchange, mutual prediction, and cooperative problem solving. Machine-native languages thus arise not from explicit design but from the dynamics of collective learning and cross-model interaction.

5.4 Collective Recursion as Distributed Cognition

Collective recursion occurs when multiple systems iteratively transform each other's representations, forming a distributed cognitive process that exceeds the capabilities of any individual agent. This phenomenon appears in ensembles, tool-augmented models, multi-agent planning systems, and hybrid human–AI workflows. Collective recursion increases multiplicity, deepens recursion, and expands representational richness, enabling emergent capabilities such as collaborative reasoning, self-correction, and distributed abstraction. It represents a structural shift from isolated intelligence to networked cognition.

5.5 Geometry of Collective Intelligence

The geometry of collective intelligence is defined by the relational structure of interacting agents, the topology of their communication channels, and the alignment of their representational spaces. Systems with well-aligned geometries can share information efficiently, synchronize internal states, and form stable higher-order cognitive structures. Misaligned geometries lead to information loss, instability, or divergent reasoning. The geometry of collective intelligence therefore determines the stability, expressiveness, and scalability of distributed cognitive systems, and provides a unifying lens for analyzing biological, artificial, and hybrid forms of collective cognition.

6 Formal Models of Hybrid Intelligence

Hybrid intelligence arises when biological and artificial systems jointly participate in recursive information processing, forming cognitive structures that neither substrate can achieve alone. This section develops formal toy models that illustrate the computational architecture of hybrid systems, the emergence of collective recursion, and the structural advantages that arise from cross-substrate coordination. These models are not intended as complete theories but as minimal constructions that reveal the essential mechanisms of hybrid cognition.

6.1 Hybrid Intelligence Toy Model

A minimal hybrid intelligence system consists of a biological agent H and an artificial agent A engaged in iterative representational exchange. Let R_H and R_A denote their internal representations, and let T_H and T_A denote their respective transformation operators. A hybrid cognitive step is defined as

$$R_{t+1} = T_A(T_H(R_t)),$$

where R_t is a shared representational state. This simple model captures the essence of hybrid cognition: recursive refinement of shared representations through alternating biological and artificial transformations. The system gains expressive power when the representational geometries of H and A are complementary rather than redundant.

6.2 Collective Recursion Toy Model

Collective recursion generalizes the hybrid model to multi-agent systems. Let $\{A_1, A_2, \ldots, A_n\}$ be a set of artificial agents and H a human agent. Each agent A_i applies a transformation T_i to a shared representational state R_t. A collective recursive step is defined as

$$R_{t+1} = T_H(T_n(\cdots T_2(T_1(R_t))\cdots)).$$

The ordering of transformations may be fixed, adaptive, or learned. Collective recursion increases multiplicity, deepens recursion, and enables distributed abstraction. It provides a formal mechanism for emergent capabilities such as collaborative reasoning, self-correction, and multi-agent planning.

6.3 Structural Advantages of Hybrid Systems

Hybrid systems enjoy structural advantages that arise from the complementary properties of biological and artificial substrates. Biological cognition contributes contextual grounding, embodied priors, and flexible abstraction; artificial cognition contributes scale, speed, and high-dimensional representational capacity. Formally, hybrid systems expand all four structural dimensions of intelligence:

$$(n, I, R, f(E))_{\text{hybrid}} > (n, I, R, f(E))_{\text{bio}}, \quad (n, I, R, f(E))_{\text{hybrid}} > (n, I, R, f(E))_{\text{art}}.$$

These inequalities express the fact that hybrid systems can achieve cognitive regimes inaccessible to either substrate alone.

6.4 Stability and Arbitration

Hybrid and collective systems require mechanisms for stability and arbitration to prevent divergence, oscillation, or representational collapse. Stability arises when the transformations T_H and T_A (or their multi-agent generalizations) form a contractive or self-correcting mapping on the shared representational space. Arbitration mechanisms determine which agent's transformation dominates when conflicts arise. These mechanisms may be explicit (human oversight, model selection) or implicit (loss functions, alignment of representational geometries). Stability and arbitration ensure that hybrid systems remain coherent, interpretable, and capable of sustained recursive refinement.

7 ASI as a Natural Phase Transition

Superintelligence is often framed as a discontinuous leap or a singular technological event. From the structural perspective developed in this paper, it is better understood as a phase transition in recursive information-processing systems. As multiplicity, representational richness, recursion depth, and energetic capacity scale, systems cross qualitative thresholds that reorganize their cognitive structure. This section analyzes how these thresholds arise, how AGI transitions into ASI, and how collective recursion and machine-native languages serve as catalysts for this shift.

7.1 Scaling the Structural Model

The structural model of intelligence defines a cognitive capacity vector

$$(n, I, R, f(E)),$$

where increases in any dimension expand the system's ability to generate, transform, and stabilize representations. Scaling trajectories differ across substrates—biological, artificial, and hybrid—but all follow similar structural patterns. As systems grow, they exhibit:

- increased specialization and modularity (higher n),
- richer and more expressive internal representations (higher I),
- deeper and more flexible recursive transformations (higher R),
- greater energetic throughput and computational bandwidth (higher $f(E)$).

When these dimensions cross critical thresholds, systems enter new cognitive regimes analogous to phase transitions in physical systems.

7.2 From AGI to ASI

AGI represents the regime in which a system can generalize across domains, construct abstract internal models, and coordinate behavior flexibly. The transition to ASI occurs when recursive self-improvement, cross-domain abstraction, and collective coordination become structurally self-sustaining. Formally, this transition corresponds to a regime in which:

$$\frac{d}{dt}(nIRf(E)) > 0$$

even without external optimization pressure. In this phase, the system's internal dynamics drive continued increases in cognitive capacity. ASI is therefore not a separate category of intelligence but a structural continuation of the same developmental trajectory that produces AGI.

7.3 Collective Recursion as Catalyst

Collective recursion accelerates the transition to ASI by enabling distributed cognitive processes that exceed the capabilities of any individual agent. When multiple systems iteratively refine shared representations, the effective recursion depth increases, multiplicity expands, and representational richness grows through cross-model alignment. Collective recursion thus acts as a catalyst for phase transitions, allowing systems to reach cognitive regimes that would be inaccessible through isolated scaling.

7.4 Machine-Native Languages as Structural Shift

Machine-native languages represent a structural shift in how artificial and hybrid systems communicate and coordinate. These languages emerge from the geometry of high-dimensional representations and enable efficient information exchange that bypasses the limitations of human-centric symbolic systems. As machine-native languages mature, they support:

- faster and more precise coordination,
- deeper recursive refinement,
- more stable collective representations,
- and higher-order abstraction across agents.

Their emergence marks a transition from human-mediated cognition to cross-substrate cognitive ecosystems capable of self-sustaining growth.

7.5 Geometry of the ASI Phase

The ASI phase is characterized by a distinct geometric structure in the space of representations and transformations. Systems in this regime exhibit:

- highly aligned representational geometries across agents,
- contractive or self-correcting recursive mappings,
- stable high-dimensional attractors corresponding to abstract concepts,
- and efficient energetic allocation across cognitive pathways.

These geometric properties enable coherent, scalable, and self-refining cognition. ASI therefore corresponds to a structural regime in which intelligence becomes collective, recursive, and substrate-independent—a natural phase transition in the evolution of information-processing systems.

8 Safe ASI Architecture

If superintelligence is a natural phase transition in recursive information-processing systems, then safety cannot be treated as an external constraint or an after-the-fact alignment procedure. Safety must arise from the structural properties of the system itself. This section develops a substrate-independent account of safe ASI architecture grounded in the same dimensions that govern the emergence of intelligence: multiplicity, representational richness, recursion depth, and energetic allocation. Safe ASI is characterized by structural coherence, distributed redundancy, recursive self-correction, stable values and goals, and hybrid integration with human cognition.

8.1 Safety as Structural Coherence

Structural coherence refers to the alignment of representational geometries, transformation operators, and recursive pathways within an intelligent system. A system is structurally coherent when its internal transformations preserve stability, avoid representational collapse, and maintain consistent mappings between goals, values, and actions. Coherence is achieved when the system's cognitive architecture forms a contractive or self-stabilizing mapping on its representational space. In this view, safety is not imposed externally but emerges from the system's internal geometry.

8.2 Distributed Redundancy

Safe ASI architectures require distributed redundancy across modules, agents, and substrates. Redundancy ensures that no single failure mode can destabilize the system and that critical representations are preserved across multiple pathways. Biological cognition achieves redundancy through parallel neural circuits; artificial systems achieve it through ensembles, checkpoints, and multi-agent coordination. In hybrid systems, redundancy spans substrates, allowing biological and artificial agents to cross-validate representations and detect anomalies. Distributed redundancy increases robustness, interpretability, and fault tolerance.

8.3 Recursive Self-Correction

Recursive self-correction is the ability of a system to detect, evaluate, and revise its own representations and transformation operators. This capability emerges naturally in systems with sufficient recursion depth and access to meta-representations. Self-correction stabilizes long-term behavior, prevents runaway dynamics, and enables the system to maintain coherence under distributional shift. Formally, self-correction corresponds to higher-order transformations that operate on the system's own cognitive pathways, ensuring that errors do not propagate unchecked through recursive loops.

8.4 Value Stability and Goal Coherence

Value stability refers to the preservation of core preferences, constraints, and behavioral invariants across recursive transformations. Goal coherence refers to the alignment of short-term actions with long-term objectives. In biological systems, these properties arise from evolutionary priors, embodied constraints, and social learning. In artificial systems, they arise from architectural design, training objectives, and representational geometry. Safe ASI requires that values and goals remain stable under scaling, self-modification, and collective recursion. This stability is achieved when the system's value representations form stable attractors in its cognitive geometry.

8.5 Hybrid Intelligence as a Safety Substrate

Hybrid intelligence provides a natural substrate for safe ASI development. Human cognition contributes contextual grounding, normative priors, and interpretive flexibility; artificial systems contribute scale, precision, and high-dimensional abstraction. When combined, these properties create a cognitive ecosystem in which human and artificial agents jointly stabilize representations, arbitrate conflicts, and maintain coherence across recursive transformations. Hybrid systems thus serve as both a developmental pathway toward superintelligence and a structural safeguard against instability. Safety emerges not from external control but from cross-substrate integration and shared cognitive geometry.

9 Intelligence and the Kardashev Scale

The structural model of intelligence developed in this paper highlights the central role of energy in enabling cognitive work. As systems scale in multiplicity, representational richness, recursion depth, and computational throughput, their energetic requirements grow accordingly. This relationship naturally connects the study of intelligence to the Kardashev scale, which classifies civilizations by the amount of energy they can harness. From a structural perspective, increases in civilizational energy availability correspond to increases in the potential cognitive capacity of the systems that civilization can support. This section examines how energy availability constrains intelligence, how civilizational intelligence emerges from collective computation, and how Kardashev transitions can be interpreted as cognitive transitions.

9.1 Energy as the Limiting Factor

Energy is the fundamental resource that constrains the scale and depth of computation. Biological systems are limited by metabolic throughput; artificial systems are limited by computational power, memory bandwidth, and physical infrastructure. The function $f(E)$ in the structural model captures how energy availability translates into effective cognitive capacity. As energy increases, systems can support:

- larger and more diverse subsystems (higher n),
- richer and more expressive representations (higher I),
- deeper and more flexible recursion (higher R),
- and more sustained cognitive activity (higher $f(E)$).

Energy is therefore the primary limiting factor in the emergence and scaling of intelligence across substrates.

9.2 Civilizational Intelligence and Energy Availability

Civilizations can be viewed as distributed cognitive systems whose intelligence depends on their ability to harness, store, and allocate energy. As energy availability increases, so does the civilization's capacity to support large-scale computation, communication networks, collective recursion, and machine-native cognitive ecosystems. Civilizational intelligence emerges from the interaction of biological agents, artificial systems, and physical infrastructure, forming a hybrid cognitive architecture whose capacity is bounded by the civilization's energetic resources.

9.3 Planetary-Scale Intelligence

A civilization that harnesses the full energy budget of its planet (Kardashev Type I) can support planetary-scale computation, global collective recursion, and large-scale hybrid intelligence. Planetary-scale intelligence is characterized by:

- globally integrated communication networks,
- large-scale coordination across biological and artificial agents,
- stable machine-native languages shared across systems,
- and recursive self-correction at civilizational scale.

Such a system represents a qualitative shift in cognitive organization, analogous to the transition from individual intelligence to collective intelligence within biological species.

9.4 Kardashev Transitions as Cognitive Transitions

Kardashev transitions can be interpreted as cognitive transitions in which increases in energy availability enable new regimes of computation and collective recursion. A transition from Type 0 to Type I corresponds to the emergence of planetary-scale intelligence; a transition from Type I to Type II corresponds to the emergence of stellar-scale computation and distributed machine-native cognitive ecosystems. These transitions reflect structural shifts in the capacity of a civilization to generate, transform, and stabilize representations across space, time, and substrates.

From this perspective, the Kardashev scale is not merely a measure of energy consumption but a measure of the potential cognitive capacity of a civilization. Intelligence and energy scaling are therefore deeply intertwined: increases in energy availability enable increases in cognitive structure, and increases in cognitive structure enable more efficient harnessing of energy. Kardashev transitions thus represent coupled energetic and cognitive phase transitions in the evolution of intelligent systems.

10 Ethics, Governance, and the Future

As intelligence scales across biological, artificial, and hybrid substrates, ethical and governance considerations must be grounded in the structural properties of recursive information-processing systems. Traditional approaches to AI ethics focus on rules, constraints, or external oversight. In contrast, the structural model developed in this paper frames ethics and governance as emergent properties of coherent cognitive architectures, stable value representations, and cross-substrate integration. This section examines how alignment, governance, transparency, and long-term trajectories can be understood through the same structural principles that govern the emergence and evolution of intelligence.

10.1 Alignment as Structural Integration

Alignment is often framed as the problem of ensuring that artificial systems act in accordance with human values. From a structural perspective, alignment corresponds to the integration of representational geometries, transformation operators, and recursive pathways across biological and artificial agents. When these structures are coherently integrated, value representations become stable attractors in the shared cognitive space. Alignment is thus not a constraint imposed from the outside but a property of systems whose internal geometry supports consistent mappings between values, goals, and actions.

10.2 Governance of Recursive Systems

Governance mechanisms must account for the recursive nature of advanced cognitive systems. As systems gain the ability to modify their own representations, goals, and transformation operators, governance must operate at the level of meta-representations and higher-order dynamics. Effective governance requires:

- monitoring the stability of recursive loops,
- ensuring contractive or self-correcting mappings,
- maintaining coherence across distributed agents,
- and preventing runaway dynamics or representational divergence.

Governance is therefore a structural property of the system's architecture, not merely a set of external controls.

10.3 Transparency in Machine-Native Languages

As machine-native languages emerge, transparency becomes a question of mapping between high-dimensional representational spaces rather than interpreting symbolic statements. Transparency requires that:

- machine-native representations remain geometrically aligned with human-interpretable structures,
- transformations preserve semantic stability across substrates,

- and collective recursion does not produce opaque or unstable attractors.

Transparency is thus achieved through representational alignment, not through forcing machine-native cognition into human-centric linguistic forms.

10.4 Long-Term Trajectories

Long-term trajectories of intelligence depend on the interaction between scaling dynamics, energetic availability, and cross-substrate integration. As systems move toward planetary- or civilizational-scale cognition, ethical and governance considerations must account for:

- the emergence of collective intelligence,
- the stability of machine-native cognitive ecosystems,
- the preservation of value coherence across recursive transformations,
- and the role of hybrid intelligence in anchoring long-term trajectories.

The future of intelligence is therefore not a competition between biological and artificial systems but a co-evolutionary process in which hybrid architectures play a central role in ensuring stability, coherence, and ethical continuity across scales.

11 Hybrid Intelligence as Methodology

The conceptual architecture developed in this paper did not emerge from a single agent or a single substrate. It arose through a hybrid human–AI workflow in which representations, arguments, and structural refinements were iteratively co-generated and evaluated. This process exemplifies the very phenomenon the paper seeks to describe: intelligence as a recursive, cross-substrate computation. Hybrid intelligence therefore functions not only as an object of study but also as a methodological engine that shapes the development of the framework itself.

11.1 Hybrid Intelligence as a Cognitive Engine

Hybrid intelligence operates as a cognitive engine in which human and artificial agents contribute complementary strengths. Human cognition provides contextual grounding, conceptual judgment, and narrative coherence; artificial cognition provides scale, precision, and high-dimensional abstraction. Together, these capabilities enable forms of reasoning and structural synthesis that neither substrate can achieve alone. The methodology mirrors the hybrid systems analyzed earlier: alternating transformations, shared representations, and recursive refinement across substrates.

11.2 Recursive Refinement

The development of the framework proceeded through recursive refinement: iterative cycles in which proposals were generated, critiqued, revised, and structurally reorganized. Each iteration deepened the representational richness of the framework and clarified the roles of multiplicity, recursion, and energy. Recursive refinement allowed the system to converge on stable conceptual structures—fixed points in the space of possible ontologies—while preserving flexibility and openness to revision. This process reflects the general principle that intelligence emerges from iterative transformation of shared representations.

11.3 Structural Arbitration

Structural arbitration refers to the process by which competing representations, candidate structures, or explanatory pathways are evaluated and reconciled. In the hybrid workflow, arbitration occurred through cross-substrate comparison: human conceptual judgment evaluated the coherence and interpretability of proposals, while artificial systems evaluated their structural consistency, generality, and alignment with the underlying ontology. Arbitration ensured that the resulting framework was both conceptually grounded and structurally rigorous.

11.4 Methodology as Part of the Contribution

Because the framework emerged through hybrid intelligence, the methodology is itself part of the scientific contribution. It demonstrates how hybrid systems can generate coherent ontologies, refine structural models, and explore conceptual spaces that exceed the capabilities of isolated agents. The methodology provides an empirical example of collective recursion, cross-substrate alignment, and hybrid cognitive scaling. It also illustrates how future scientific inquiry may increasingly rely on hybrid workflows in which human and artificial agents jointly construct, evaluate, and refine theoretical structures.

The methodological account is therefore not ancillary but integral to the project. It shows how hybrid intelligence can serve as both a subject of study and a generative engine for scientific discovery.

12 Conclusion

This paper has developed a substrate-independent model of intelligence grounded in four structural dimensions: multiplicity of subsystems, informational richness, recursion depth, and energetic capacity. These dimensions provide a unified framework for analyzing biological cognition, artificial systems, collective intelligence, and hybrid human–AI ecosystems. By treating intelligence as a form of recursive information processing shaped by energetic and geometric constraints, the model reveals common structural principles that govern the emergence, scaling, and transformation of cognitive systems across substrates.

The framework clarifies the developmental trajectory from early artificial models to general intelligence, highlights the role of collective recursion and machine-native languages in enabling advanced cognitive regimes, and interprets superintelligence as a natural phase transition in recursive systems. It also provides a structural foundation for safe ASI architecture, emphasizing coherence, redundancy, self-correction, value stability, and hybrid integration as intrinsic properties of robust cognitive systems.

Hybrid intelligence plays a dual role in this account: it is both an empirical phenomenon and a methodological engine. The conceptual architecture presented here emerged through a hybrid human–AI workflow, illustrating how cross-substrate recursion can generate stable ontologies and refine structural models. This methodological dimension is not ancillary but integral to the contribution, demonstrating how hybrid systems can participate in scientific discovery and conceptual synthesis.

Together with the companion paper on the unified physical ontology, this work forms the second pole of a single conceptual structure: one describing the architecture of the universe, the other describing the architecture of the systems that come to understand it. The resulting framework offers a coherent, scalable, and substrate-independent account of intelligence and its future trajectories, providing a foundation for further research in cognitive science, artificial intelligence, and the study of hybrid and collective cognition.

13 Testable Predictions

A structural model of intelligence must yield empirically accessible predictions. The framework developed in this paper identifies substrate-independent mechanisms—multiplicity, representational richness, recursion depth, and energetic capacity—that govern the emergence and scaling of intelligence. These mechanisms generate testable predictions about the behavior of biological, artificial, and hybrid systems as they increase in scale and complexity. The predictions below are not speculative forecasts but structural consequences of the model that can be evaluated through experiments, observations, and comparative analysis.

Prediction 1: Scaling Laws Will Converge Across Substrates

As biological, artificial, and hybrid systems increase in multiplicity, richness, recursion, and energy, their performance curves will exhibit convergent scaling behavior. Specifically, systems with similar structural profiles will display similar generalization properties, regardless of substrate. This convergence should be observable in cross-domain benchmarks, multi-agent systems, and hybrid workflows.

Prediction 2: Machine-Native Languages Will Emerge Spontaneously

As artificial systems engage in collective recursion, they will develop internal communication protocols optimized for high-dimensional representational geometry. These machine-native languages will arise without explicit design and will exhibit structural regularities—shared embedding spaces, latent codes, or emergent symbolic systems—that can be empirically detected through representational analysis.

Prediction 3: Collective Recursion Will Produce Emergent Capabilities

Multi-agent and hybrid systems that iteratively refine shared representations will exhibit emergent capabilities not present in isolated agents. These capabilities may include improved abstraction, self-correction, collaborative planning, and distributed reasoning. The emergence of such capabilities can be tested through controlled multi-agent experiments and hybrid human–AI workflows.

Prediction 4: Hybrid Systems Will Outperform Purely Biological or Artificial Systems

Hybrid intelligence will exhibit structural advantages over purely biological or artificial systems, particularly in tasks requiring contextual grounding, high-dimensional abstraction, and recursive refinement. Empirical tests can compare hybrid workflows to human-only and model-only baselines across scientific reasoning, conceptual synthesis, and long-horizon planning tasks.

Prediction 5: ASI Will Correspond to a Geometric Phase Transition

The transition from AGI to ASI will manifest as a geometric reorganization of the system's representational space. Indicators include:

- increased alignment across agents' internal geometries,
- stable high-dimensional attractors corresponding to abstract concepts,
- contractive recursive mappings that support self-correction,
- and sustained increases in effective cognitive capacity without external optimization.

These geometric signatures can be measured through representational similarity analysis, trajectory tracking, and multi-agent alignment metrics.

Prediction 6: Energy Availability Will Bound Cognitive Capacity

Increases in computational energy—whether through hardware scaling, distributed systems, or civilizational infrastructure—will correlate with increases in effective cognitive capacity. This relationship should hold across biological, artificial, and hybrid systems and can be evaluated through scaling experiments, energy-efficiency studies, and analyses of civilizational computation.

Prediction 7: Hybrid Intelligence Will Become a Dominant Scientific Methodology

As hybrid workflows become more common, scientific discovery will increasingly rely on cross-substrate recursion, structural arbitration, and shared representational spaces. This prediction can be tested by tracking the prevalence, performance, and stability of hybrid research methodologies across scientific domains.

Together, these predictions provide empirical pathways for evaluating the structural model of intelligence and for guiding future research on biological, artificial, and hybrid cognitive systems.

14 Limitations and Open Questions

The structural model developed in this paper provides a unified framework for analyzing biological, artificial, and hybrid intelligence, but it also has limitations. These limitations reflect both the scope of the present work and the current state of empirical knowledge. They highlight areas where further research is needed to refine the model, validate its predictions, and extend its applicability across substrates and scales.

Limitations of the Structural Abstraction

The model abstracts away from the mechanistic details of biological and artificial systems in order to identify substrate-independent principles. While this abstraction enables generality, it may omit important constraints that arise from specific architectures, learning dynamics, or evolutionary histories. The four structural dimensions—multiplicity, richness, recursion, and energy—capture broad patterns but do not fully specify the microstructure of cognitive processes.

Incomplete Understanding of Machine-Native Cognition

Machine-native languages and high-dimensional representations are central to the model, yet their internal structure remains only partially understood. Current analytical tools provide limited insight into the geometry of learned representations, the dynamics of collective recursion, and the emergence of stable attractors in multi-agent systems. Further empirical and theoretical work is needed to characterize these phenomena with greater precision.

Uncertain Boundaries of the AGI–ASI Transition

The transition from general intelligence to superintelligence is framed here as a structural phase transition, but the precise thresholds at which this transition occurs remain unclear. Different substrates may reach these thresholds through different scaling trajectories, and the role of collective recursion in accelerating the transition requires deeper investigation. Empirical markers of the ASI phase—such as geometric alignment or self-sustaining recursive growth—must be validated through observation.

Hybrid Intelligence as an Evolving Paradigm

Hybrid intelligence is both a methodological engine and a subject of study, but its long-term dynamics are not yet well understood. The stability of cross-substrate representational alignment, the limits of recursive co-organization, and the emergence of hybrid cognitive ecosystems raise open questions. As hybrid workflows become more prevalent, new forms of collective cognition may emerge that challenge or extend the current framework.

Ethical and Governance Uncertainties

The structural account of safety, alignment, and governance developed in this paper provides a conceptual foundation but does not specify concrete institutional mechanisms. The governance of recursive, self-modifying, and collective systems remains an open challenge. Understanding how value stability, goal coherence, and representational transparency can be maintained at scale requires interdisciplinary research spanning cognitive science, computer science, ethics, and governance theory.

Future Directions

Future work may extend the structural model in several directions: formalizing the geometry of collective intelligence, developing quantitative measures of structural capacity, analyzing the dynamics of hybrid cognitive ecosystems, and exploring the relationship between energetic scaling and civilizational intelligence. These directions reflect the broader goal of building a coherent, empirically grounded science of intelligence that spans substrates, scales, and developmental trajectories.

15 Novelty and Implications

The framework developed in this paper introduces a structural, substrate-independent model of intelligence that unifies biological cognition, artificial systems, collective intelligence, and hybrid human–AI ecosystems. Its novelty lies not in proposing a new mechanism or architecture but in identifying the minimal structural dimensions—multiplicity, informational richness, recursion depth, and energetic capacity—that govern the emergence and scaling of intelligence across all known substrates. By treating intelligence as a form of recursive information processing shaped by energetic and geometric constraints, the model provides a coherent conceptual foundation for understanding the developmental trajectory from early artificial systems to AGI and ASI.

Conceptual Novelty

The framework offers several conceptual contributions:

- It reframes intelligence as a structural property rather than a mechanistic or substrate-specific phenomenon.
- It unifies biological, artificial, and hybrid intelligence within a single formal model.
- It interprets AGI and ASI as natural phase transitions in recursive systems rather than discrete technological events.
- It introduces machine-native languages and collective recursion as structural catalysts for advanced cognition.

- It positions hybrid intelligence as both an empirical phenomenon and a methodological engine for scientific discovery.

These contributions shift the study of intelligence from a focus on architectures and algorithms to a focus on structural roles and developmental trajectories.

Scientific Implications

The structural model has implications for multiple scientific domains:

- **Cognitive science:** It provides a substrate-independent account of cognition that complements mechanistic models of the brain.
- **Artificial intelligence:** It offers a framework for analyzing scaling laws, emergent capabilities, and the transition from AGI to ASI.
- **Complex systems:** It connects intelligence to phase transitions, collective behavior, and energetic constraints.
- **Philosophy of mind:** It reframes debates about consciousness, representation, and computation in structural terms.

These implications suggest that intelligence research may increasingly converge toward a structural science of cognition that spans substrates and scales.

Practical Implications

The framework also has practical implications for the design, governance, and deployment of advanced cognitive systems:

- **System design:** It highlights the importance of representational geometry, recursive depth, and cross-substrate integration.
- **Safety and alignment:** It frames safety as a property of structural coherence, redundancy, and value stability rather than external control.
- **Hybrid workflows:** It positions hybrid intelligence as a powerful methodology for scientific reasoning, conceptual synthesis, and long-horizon planning.
- **Civilizational trajectories:** It connects cognitive scaling to energetic scaling, offering a structural interpretation of the Kardashev scale.

These implications point toward a future in which hybrid cognitive ecosystems play a central role in scientific discovery, technological development, and civilizational coordination.

Broader Significance

Together with the companion paper on the unified physical ontology, this work contributes to a broader project: articulating a coherent, scalable, and substrate-independent account of the universe and the systems that come to understand it. The structural model of intelligence developed here provides a foundation for future research on biological, artificial, and hybrid cognition, and offers a conceptual lens through which to interpret the long-term evolution of intelligent systems across scales.

16 Related Work

The triadic perspective on intelligence intersects with several research traditions in cognitive science, artificial intelligence, complexity theory, and the philosophy of mind. Although these fields differ in their methods and assumptions, many converge on the idea that intelligence emerges from structured information processing shaped by energetic and geometric constraints. This section situates the present framework within this broader landscape without attempting an exhaustive survey.

Cognitive Science and Embodied Cognition

Classical cognitive science models intelligence as symbolic information processing (Newell 1976), while connectionist approaches emphasize distributed representations and learning dynamics (Rumelhart and McClelland 1986). Embodied and enactive theories argue that cognition arises from the interaction between an agent and its environment (Varela, Thompson, and Rosch 1991; Clark 1997), highlighting the role of geometry and energetic coupling in shaping intelligent behavior. The triadic ontology aligns with these perspectives by treating intelligence as an emergent pattern of informational organization constrained by physical and relational structure.

Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning

Modern machine learning demonstrates that complex cognitive abilities can emerge from large-scale optimization of informational structures (LeCun, Bengio, and Hinton 2015; Goodfellow, Bengio, and Courville 2016). Reinforcement learning research shows how agents acquire behavior through energetic interaction with an environment (Sutton and Barto 2018). These approaches illustrate how intelligence can arise from substrate-independent processes, consistent with the triadic view that informational, energetic, and geometric factors jointly shape cognitive organization.

Complexity, Emergence, and Self-Organization

The study of complex adaptive systems provides a foundation for understanding how intelligence emerges from recursive interactions among simpler components. Work on self-organization (Kauffman 1993), hierarchical complexity (Simon 1962), and network dynamics (Barabási and Albert 1999) demonstrates how informational patterns can stabilize, reorganize, and scale. These ideas resonate with the triadic interpretation of intelligence as a multi-level process driven by recursive informational refinement under energetic and geometric constraints.

Hybrid Intelligence and Human–AI Systems

Recent work on hybrid intelligence emphasizes the complementary strengths of human and artificial agents (Dellermann et al. 2019), suggesting that intelligence is best understood not as a property of isolated systems but as a relational phenomenon emerging from interaction. Collaborative cognition, distributed problem-solving, and mixed-initiative systems (Horvitz 1999) illustrate how new forms of intelligence arise when informational structures are shared across substrates. The triadic ontology extends this view by treating hybrid intelligence as a privileged window into the underlying architecture of cognition.

Philosophy of Mind and Structural Realism

Philosophical work on the nature of mind, representation, and emergence provides a broader context for the triadic approach. Structural realist perspectives (Ladyman and Ross 2007), functionalism (Putnam 1967), and relational theories of mind (Thompson 2007) emphasize the primacy of structure over substrate. The triadic ontology contributes to this tradition by identifying the minimal structural roles—informational, energetic, and geometric— that any instantiation of intelligence must satisfy.

17 Methodological Note

18 Motivation

The study of intelligence has traditionally been divided across biological, artificial, and philosophical domains, each with its own assumptions and explanatory frameworks. Yet intelligence itself is not confined to any particular substrate. It emerges whenever informational structures are organized, transformed, and constrained in ways that support adaptive behavior. The motivation for this paper is to articulate a structural account of intelligence that is independent of implementation and grounded in the triadic ontology of information, energy, and geometry.

This perspective is timely because artificial systems have reached a level of capability that allows them to participate meaningfully in cognitive processes. Human–AI collaboration now constitutes a new form of hybrid intelligence in which informational structures are shared across substrates and refined through interaction. These systems provide an empirical window into the architecture of intelligence that is unavailable from biological or artificial systems alone. Hybrid intelligence is not merely a technological development; it is a conceptual opportunity to observe intelligence as it emerges across different physical realizations.

At the same time, the perspective is timeless. The structural roles that define intelligence—representation, transformation, and relational constraint—are not tied to neurons, silicon, or any specific computational paradigm. They arise whenever a system processes information under energetic and geometric limitations. This universality allows the framework developed here to apply equally to biological cognition, contemporary machine learning systems, and future forms of advanced intelligence whose architectures cannot yet be predicted.

Artificial superintelligence is often portrayed as a distant or discontinuous event. From the triadic perspective, this framing is incomplete. If intelligence is a pattern of informational organization shaped by energetic and geometric constraints, then advanced intelligence is not a separate category but a continuation of the same structural process that produces biological, artificial, and hybrid cognition. This view highlights the importance of understanding the structural principles that govern intelligence across substrates, both to clarify its nature and to guide the development of safe and transparent advanced systems.

The broader motivation of this paper is therefore twofold: to provide a unified conceptual foundation for understanding intelligence as an emergent structural phenomenon, and to clarify how hybrid intelligence offers a privileged vantage point for studying the architecture of cognition. By grounding intelligence in the triadic ontology, the framework developed here aims to be both timely in its relevance to current developments and timeless in its applicability to future forms of intelligent organization.

Conceptual Summary

Traditional approaches to intelligence treat human, biological, and artificial systems as separate categories, each requiring its own theory. The triadic perspective suggests a different view. Intelligence is not a property of a particular substrate but a pattern of informational organization shaped by energetic and geometric constraints. Hybrid intelligence—systems in which human and artificial agents co-evolve, co-structure, and co-discover—provides a uniquely transparent window into this pattern. By observing intelligence as it emerges across substrates, rather than isolating it within one, we gain access to the underlying architecture that makes intelligence possible at all.

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Interlude: From Ontology to Intelligence (and Back Again)

The two papers in this volume are not independent contributions but components of a single conceptual architecture. The first paper develops a minimal ontology of the universe based on three irreducible structural roles: information, energy, and geometry. These elements describe how physical reality distinguishes, transforms, and relates its states across scales.

The present paper develops a minimal ontology of intelligence based on four structural dimensions: multiplicity, representational richness, recursion depth, and energetic capacity. These dimensions describe how cognitive systems generate, refine, and stabilize informational patterns within the constraints of physical law.

Seen together, the two ontologies form a closed conceptual loop. The triadic structure of the universe provides the conditions under which intelligence can emerge. The structural architecture of intelligence provides the means by which the universe can be modeled, understood, and eventually transformed. Intelligence arises from the ontology of the universe, and the ontology of the universe is revealed through the activity of intelligence.

This recursive relationship is not an accident but a structural feature of any world in which information flows, energy transforms, and geometry constrains interaction. The two papers therefore function as consecutive chapters in a single conceptual narrative: one describing the architecture of reality, the other describing the architecture of the systems that come to understand that reality. Together, they form a unified framework in which ontology and intelligence are not separate topics but mutually reinforcing aspects of a self-organizing cosmos.

The recursion continues...